

Ahmad Barakat | ITEC 312 | IT/Security Meetup

ORCA Security - Kevin

The day to day responsibilities he mentioned was consulting with Tech firms who are looking to protect their applications throughout the whole process, before launching into the cloud and while it is deployed. When I asked what he had done to get in his position he explained that he started in networking, then security analytics and worked his way into application security. The most in demand IT skills he mentioned was Security+, then any cloud software such as AWS, or Microsoft Azure. He mentioned that staying on top of new trends could be handled by always looking to absorb new information and looking at important certifications to acquire even after you have your degree. The advice he gave me as someone starting in the IT field was to get certified during my breaks within the school year, and keep applying to internships and entry level jobs until you find something that aligns with your interests or desires. He mentioned that the most rewarding part of his job is being able to help companies secure their application, and the fact that he could do all of that from a remote environment. I let him know that I was interested in cyber security and that I have a small background in coding, and when I asked which certifications are work obtaining, he mentioned Security+, Network+, and a cloud certification like I had mentioned earlier, AWS certification or AZURE 900.

Keynote Speaker - Reet K.

While I wasn't able to have a full on conversation with questions, Reet tackled the topic of Large Language Models (LLM), the 10 biggest risks and a mitigation tactic for each risk in her presentation. She mentioned how prompt injections, model abuse, and data

leakage could be huge risks, where attackers can trick LLM with malicious prompts, use them to generate phishing emails, and reveal sensitive information. For prompt injections, the proper mitigation tactic would be to have context separation, and hardening the prompt as well as limiting the AI's permissions. For model abuse, it is important to implement a restriction of certain outputs and require user verification, and finally for data leakage, it's important to have strong access control for the model, and have encrypted sensitive prompts and continuous monitoring of its output. There are many more risks and mitigation tactics, but these were the ones that stuck with me the most from Reet's presentation, and she was able to explain and lecture in an easy and effective way where anyone could understand, I could easily tell she was an experienced speaker and that she has a great impact within the realm of Cybersecurity, locally and abroad.

Reflection

The meeting I attended was the BSidesKC April 26, 2025. This was located in the Kansas City Kansas Community College. The number of attendants was around 150-200, the focus of the meetup was a main discussion with a key speaker, company/work discussions and introductions, then what was most interesting to me was the little labs and activities they had, lock picking, working with security outlets, etc. Something that stood out to me was the focus on security throughout the whole process from beginning to end, like we discussed in class, is it better to encrypt data before launching into the cloud or after? Where the answers at the meetup were always to encrypt data before launching and it was just something that stuck with me and I could relate to from a topic in class. In all honesty, I might not attend a BSidesKC meetup but I

will look into different meetups. It lacked the social aspect, it was hard for me to approach people even though I am a pretty social person. I thought there would be a lot more connection opportunities. I feel like it was a valuable experience, the next time I attend something like this, I will likely do much more and try even more to talk to people and have questions for more company representatives.